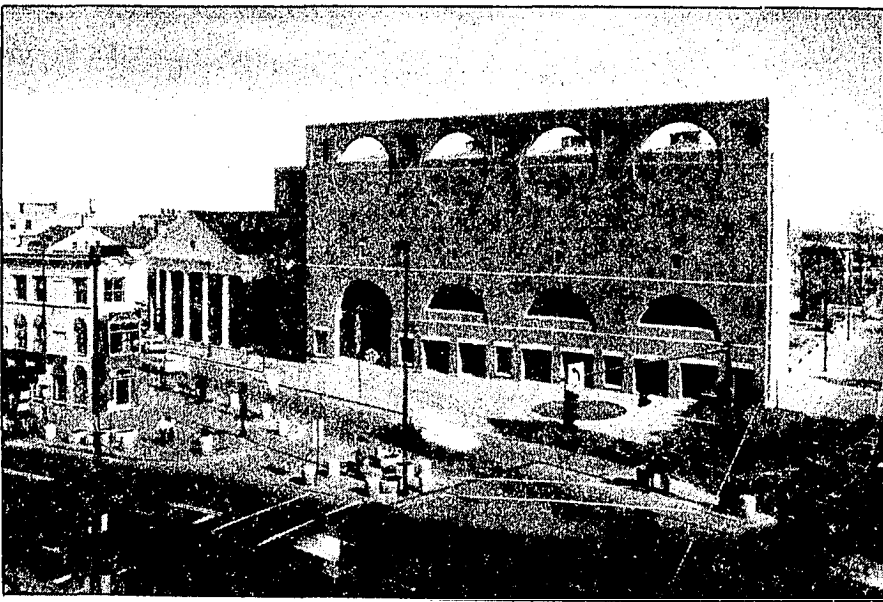


But first, the bad news...

Robert Campbell Globe Correspondent

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The Portland Museum of Art's new Charles Shipman Payson Building.

But first, the bad news . . .

BEST

The Portland Museum of Art.

Church Court

The Chinese Teahouse.

The Citgo Sign

Ohio State University Arts Center exhibit

WORST

The Kennedy's Fiasco.

A BRA Report: "Boston Tomorrow"

The Clarendon Building outrage.

The Westin Hotel at Copley Place

The Public Relations Genius of Philip Johnson

By Robert Campbell
Globe Correspondent

In architecture, this year, it somehow seems right to begin with the worsts.

The Kennedy's fiasco was doubtless the top "worst" of 1983. Probably it was the most significant event in architecture, because it summed up the most important issue, which is that 1983 is going to be remembered as the year in which everyone finally panicked at the amount of new construction being shoe-horned into downtown Boston.

Developers initially proposed, in March, an extremely disruptive, 28-story angular office tower for the site of the old Kennedy's store, a pleasant but unremarkable red-brick Victorian

building on Summer street. The Boston Preservation Alliance, an umbrella group of preservation organizations, responded by petitioning the Boston Landmarks Commission to declare the old store a landmark, and thus abort the new proposal. The developer backed off and, after negotiations with the city, returned with a compromise, preserving the facade of the old store but adding a new tower set well behind it. After a highly charged debate, the Landmarks Commission, by a single vote, accepted the compromise. The Preservation Alliance then sued the Commission in an attempt to reverse that decision and save the entire building. The suit is now pending.

The reason for citing that sad, chaotic series of events is to point out that this is what now passes for a planning process in Boston. Everyone saw the chaos, and a few perceived the real moral of the tale, which is that we should stop asking the Landmarks Commission to plan our city for us. It isn't the right body, and it doesn't have the necessary powers. As 1983 draws to a close, just about everyone is calling for some kind of more rational, more open planning process, one that will incorporate a clear vision of what the scale and character of our city should be.

A clear vision is precisely what is lacking in Worst No. 2.

After years of laboring, the Boston Redevelopment Authority brought forth a mouse entitled "Boston Tomorrow: Issues of Development." This brief yet unreadable document will surely become a model for all bureaucracies everywhere who wish to give the impression of addressing a problem without actually saying anything about it. Its vague prose amounts to no more than another promise: A second phase

of the report, we are told, will discuss actual guidelines. By my count, it is now eight years since a development plan for Boston's downtown growth was first promised.

The Clarendon Building is the oldest of the three Hancock office blocks that cluster near Copley Square. In an outrage committed on the public by the Hancock in cahoots with the board of the BRA, it's now being renovated into expensive private office space, in flagrant violation of an agreement by which Hancock was supposed to make this site available for public cultural uses.

The Westin Hotel isn't all bad by any means, but it's still a disappointment. The design, by the Architects Collaborative of Cambridge, has the virtue of modesty. The hotel wraps itself in a blanket of baby-pink fuzz (actually concrete) in an effort to hide its bulk, like an elephant zipped into an infant's sleeper. The disguise doesn't hide the disorganization of the public levels, nor the failure to create architectural form at the prominent entrance facade on Copley Square.

As for the PR genius of Philip Johnson, how else can you explain the pathetic, early-round dive taken by the Back Bay community and the Boston Society of Architects in the case of the vast new proposal by New England Life Insurance Company for a block along Boylston street? Designed by the internationally known architect Johnson and his partner, John Burgee, the New England complex is now somewhat improved but remains too high and too big in scale for its site. The community has lost leverage by not opposing the recent BRA approval.

An enthralling experience

Now the good news:

The Portland Museum of Art in Maine, by Henry N. Cobb of I. M. Pei and Partners, is one of the best new buildings in New England of this generation. It's an unpretentious, unassertive cluster of beautifully daylight galleries that offer the visitor an experience of motion through space and light, an experience that is enthralling in itself, yet that never, in the slightest, distracts attention from the works of art for whose sake the museum exists. Every painting and sculpture is at its best in the setting given it here. The exterior of the museum is idiosyncratic and perhaps more fun to puzzle over than to look at, but the interior is close to perfection of its kind.

Three works that revive, in different ways, some of the pizzazz of an earlier era:

Church Court — still unfinished — is a cluster of condominiums curling around a church ruin in the Back Bay. Designed by Graham Gund, it promises to become one of the best of recent Boston buildings. The frank yet restrained use of decorative patterns in the brickwork give it a brightness and human scale that few recent buildings possess.

The Chinese Teahouse, a delightful garden folly built originally in 1914 at Marble House, one of the Newport oceanfront estates, has been restored with rare craft and opened to the public.

And the Citgo Sign, that garish, lovely beacon over Kenmore Square, flashed on again after a petition to the Boston Landmarks Commission awakened the owner to the realization that there was still public relations value in the 1965 sign, an antique by neon standards.

Finally, kudos to the exhibit at Harvard of six designs for an arts center at Ohio State University. This beautifully mounted show of entries in a competition won by Peter Eisenman/Jacquelin Robertson of New York was the best local architectural exhibit of the year.